Best Practices: QA/Regulatory Collaboration

Effective Teamwork for Market Compliance & Consumer Safety

Agenda

1. Roles & Responsibilities: Regulatory vs. QA
2. 7 Skills for Effective Collaboration
3. QA/Regulatory Decision-Making Framework
4. Case Studies & Group Discussion
5. Key Takeaways & Next Steps

Roles & Responsibilities

Defining the Roles

REGULATORY

"What must the product legally say and claim to be compliant."

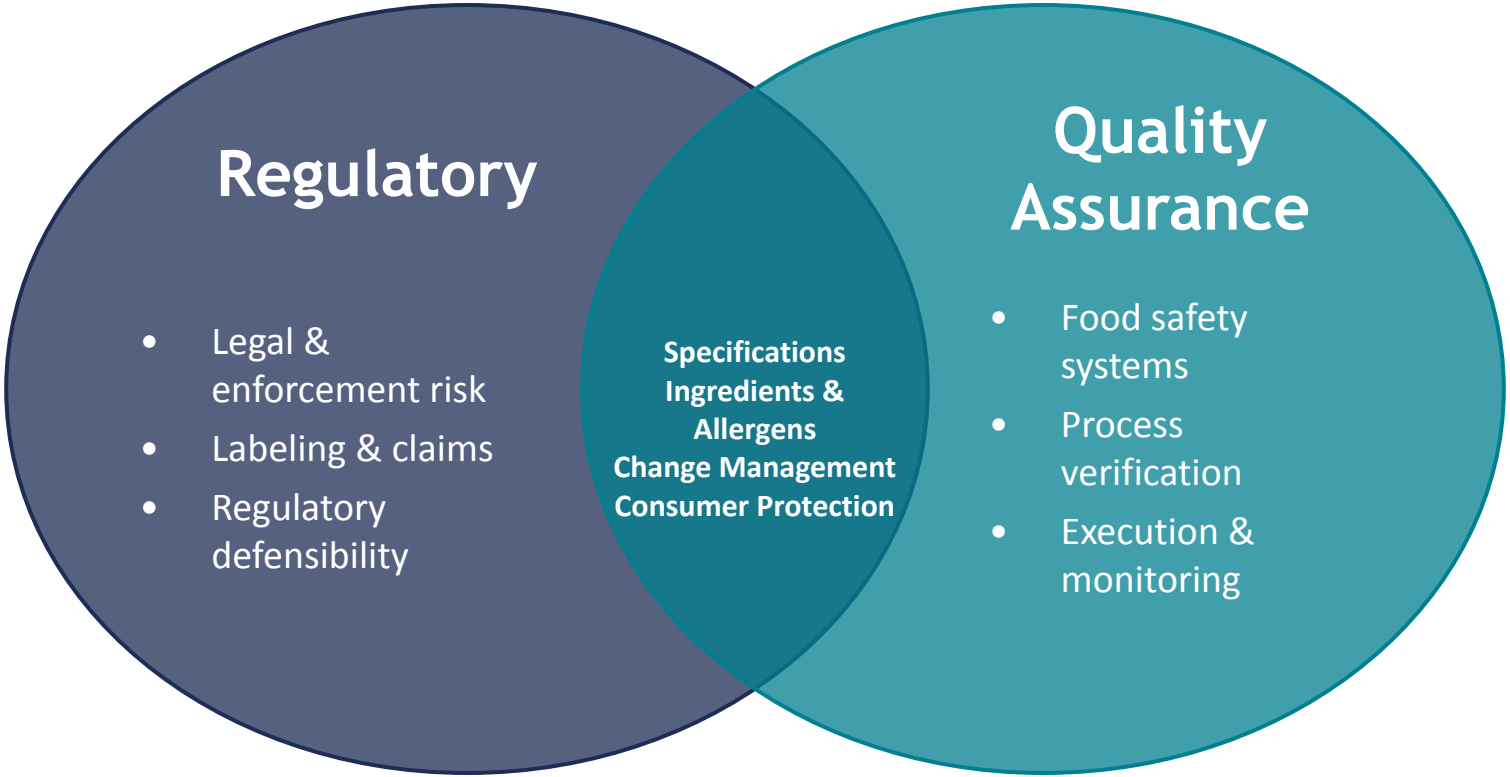
- Laws, policies & enforcement risk
- Labeling, claims & approvals
- Regulatory interpretation & defensibility

QUALITY ASSURANCE

"What the process must consistently do to make that product safely."

- Food safety systems & controls
- Supplier & process verification
- Execution, validation & monitoring

Where They Overlap



"Regulatory defines what must be true on paper.
QA ensures it is true every time we run the product."

7 Skills for Effective Collaboration

7 Key Skills

1. Shared Risk Mindset
2. Early & Continuous Engagement
3. Clear Role Clarity
4. Communication & Translation
5. Specification Discipline
6. Mutual Respect
7. Audit-Ready Documentation

Skills 1-4: Foundation for Collaboration

1 · Shared Risk Mindset

Both teams think risk first — not function first.
Always ask: “If this fails, what is the consumer risk?”

2 · Early & Continuous Engagement

Involve both teams from ideation through launch. Early collaboration prevents costly redesigns and surfaces risks sooner.

3 · Clear Role Clarity

Regulatory interprets requirements. QA verifies execution. Define ownership to prevent confusion and costly rework.

4 · Communication & Translation

Regulatory translates regulations into operational needs. QA translates process reality into compliance implications. Shared language prevents miscommunication.

Skills 5–7: Execution & Accountability

5 · Specification Discipline

- One source of truth — a single, agreed-upon specification
- No changes without documented review from both functions
- Clear data status: everyone knows what is final vs. in progress

6 · Mutual Respect

Collaboration breaks down when Regulatory is treated as a last-minute gatekeeper or QA is viewed as just execution.

Both roles carry strategic value. Respect the expertise each brings.

7 · Audit-Ready Docs

Documentation is not bureaucracy — it is protection. Every decision must be:

- Documented
- Reproducible
- Defensible months or years later

Real-World Scenario Discussion

Practical Framework for QA/Regulatory Decision-Making

Apply these five steps to walk through QA & Regulatory decisions in each case.

1 · Trigger

What changed or what went wrong? Identify the initiating event that set the scenario in motion.

2 · Risk

Assess the full impact: consumer safety, regulatory exposure, and business continuity consequences.

3 · Decision Rights

Who decides what, and when? Map the accountability between Regulatory and QA at each stage.

4 · Controls & Proof

What records, verification steps, and release gates prove the process worked as intended?

5 · Prevent Recurrence

Lock in the fix through standard work and change control so the issue never repeats.

Case Study 1: Excess Sauce on a CN Item

During a QA check, a Child Nutrition (CN) item is found to have had too much sauce applied. Walk through the collaboration spine for this scenario.

1 Trigger — 2 Risk — 3 Decision Rights — 4 Controls & Proof — 5 Prevent Recurrence

As you work through each step, consider:

- Where does QA's role end and Regulatory's begin — or do they overlap?
- What would happen if one team acted alone without looping in the other?

Case Study 2: Ingredient Label Mismatch

During incoming ingredient label verification, the plant identifies that the ingredient statement on the received material does not match the approved specification.

- Production is scheduled and no alternate ingredient is available
- Stopping the line creates significant operational and customer risk

The plant asks: “Can we run?”

1 Trigger — 2 Risk — 3 Decision Rights — 4 Controls & Proof — 5 Prevent Recurrence

As you work through each step, consider:

- Who has the authority to approve running with a non-conforming ingredient?
- What documentation would you need before the line starts?

Case Study 3: Clean Label Reformulation

Marketing would like to move forward to make products more "clean" by removing ingredients that aren't easily recognizable.

What do you need to collaborate on with QA to keep the product compliant and food safe?

1 Trigger — 2 Risk — 3 Decision Rights — 4 Controls & Proof — 5 Prevent Recurrence

As you work through each step, consider:

- What could go wrong if Marketing removes an ingredient without QA's input?
- At what point does Regulatory need to be at the table?

Key Takeaways

1. **QA and Regulatory Have Distinct Roles — But a Shared Mission**
   Regulatory ensures compliance with external standards; QA ensures internal processes deliver safe, consistent products. Both exist to protect the consumer and the brand.

2. **Collaboration Is a Skill Set — Not Just a Mindset**
   The 7 skills — from communication and mutual respect to proactive problem-solving — are concrete, practicable behaviors that strengthen the QA/Regulatory partnership every day.

3. **A Structured Framework Turns Pressure Into Process**
   When real-world issues arise — ingredient mismatches, label changes, reformulations — the 5-step collaboration spine gives teams a repeatable path from problem to resolution.

4. **Early Collaboration Prevents Costly Surprises**
   Whether it’s a spec change, a clean-label initiative, or an ingredient issue on the line — looping in the right partners early keeps products safe, compliant, and on schedule.

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Belinda Davis is the Director of FSQA Labeling & Regulatory Compliance at Tyson Foods, where she leads enterprise-wide efforts to ensure accurate, compliant product labeling. She brings 21 years of regulatory experience with Tyson and holds a degree in Food Science from the University of Arkansas. Belinda is known for translating complex USDA FSIS and FDA requirements into practical solutions that enable innovation while protecting consumers and brand integrity.